

Writing a Novel is Hard. Writing One in a *Web Chat* is Broken.

Why raw AI in a browser tab inevitably falls apart after 15,000 words—and why prompt engineering alone cannot fix it.

⚠️ THE WEB CHAT FAILURE MODES

- 💬 **The Amnesia Wall:** By Chapter 4, models forget secondary characters, drop subplots, and scramble established world rules.
- 📄 **Copy-Paste Purgatory:** Juggling fragments between browser tabs, Word, and Google Docs, losing version history and sanity.
- 🗂️ **94% Structural Detectability:** *StoryScope* research proves AI fiction is flagged from structure alone—unearned catharsis, neat apologies, and flat cadence.
- ✂️ **The Black-Box Rewrite Trap:** Prompting *"tighten pacing"* causes the AI to unilaterally obliterate your idiosyncratic author voice with synthetic oatmeal.

✨ WHAT NOVELISTS ACTUALLY NEED

- 📁 **A Local Glass-Box Studio:** Plain Markdown and JSON files on your own machine. Zero proprietary databases or subscription lock-in.
- 🕒 **A Proactive Creative Concierge:** An AI craft partner that tracks story state, preserves canon, and suggests 2 concrete next steps.
- 🛡️ **Anti-Drift & Cadence Sentry:** Sub-500ms telemetry that checks sentence rhythm and tell density without modifying author words.
- 👤 **The Sovereign Author:** The human novelist always holds the red pen. The AI diagnoses and assists; it never unilaterally rewrites.

What is Soundingboard 2.0?

The Sovereign Author Architecture.

The author is the novelist; the system bends to the author, never the author to the system. Governed by the Interpretable Context Methodology (ICM).



The File System is the Brain

Every character rule, world law, beat, and chapter playlist lives in human-readable Markdown and JSON. Open any file in Obsidian or VS Code to see exactly what your AI knows. Zero opaque vector DBs.

ICM Architecture

Zero Black Boxes



The Human Red Pen Guarantee

Soundingboard contractually forbids autonomous AI rewrites. All editorial feedback uses The Bracket Method: quarantined suggestions with 3 clear choices (Cut, Rephrase, or Keep voice).

No Silent Rewrites

The Bracket Method



Zero Runtime Dependencies

Strict zero external dependency standard (`dependencies: {}` in `package.json`). Runs entirely on native Node.js 18+ built-ins with instant sub-500ms audits.

Pure Node.js 18+

< 500ms Diagnostics



The Sovereign Mandate: "Soundingboard files contain the meaning. Git records the evolution." The author owns the creative work. Git is an open historical record, never an editorial gatekeeper.

✓ Playbook
#21

The Writer's Room & Universal Ingestion.

Write in Obsidian, Scrivener, Word, or native code agents. An inviolable creative sanctuary with zero linter nagging.

The Writer's Room Sanctuary (`writers_room/`)

A partitioned creative sandbox (`notes/`, `beats/`, `drafts/`, `inputs/`) built for pure creative flow:



Inviolable Immunity Shield

Automated linters and doctor scans strictly ignore the Writer's Room. Zero automated nag screens or red ink.



Zero Frontmatter Overhead

Draft freely without YAML headers or rigid metadata. Frontmatter is added only when graduating scenes.



Audits Only on Explicit Request

Linters only inspect raw WIP drafts when you specifically ask by path (e.g. *"Audit the rhythm of `drafts/tavern.md`"*).



Universal Ingestion & Tool Freedom

No proprietary app lock-in. Soundingboard layers over tools already on your desk:



Obsidian Vault Mode

Open the workspace folder directly in Obsidian to navigate bi-directional character wikilinks and graph views.



External Draft Ingestion

Ingest Scrivener, Word (`.docx`), or Google Docs via `soundingboard ingest`. Snapshots SHA-256 hashes and harvests canon.



Native Agent Harms

First-class harnesses for Google Antigravity, Claude Code, Gemini CLI, Cursor, and offline local LLMs via Ollama.

Scene as Dramatic Quantum.

Chapters as Playlists.

Decoupling scenes from rigid directory hierarchies. Unassigned floating scenes remain fully indexed, audited, and valid.



Atomic Scene Pool

All graduated scenes live in a flat pool (`manuscript/scenes/sc-XXXX.md`). Write your climax first, jump between acts, or draft standalone vignettes without breaking directory paths.

`sc-XXXX.md`

Stable Identity



Chapters as Playlists

Chapters in `manuscript/chapters/ch-XX.md` are lightweight playlists referencing scene IDs in reading order, complete with an authored `break_rationale` explaining the dramatic tension.

Playlist Arrays

Authored Breaks



Lossless Derived Caching

`manuscript.json` is a purely derived cache rebuilt losslessly via `node scripts/soundingboard.js reindex`. Markdown files remain the sole ground truth. Zero database corruption.

Lossless Reindex

File-First Truth

```
# manuscript/scenes/sc-0012.md (Atomic Scene Card) --- id: "sc-0012" title: "The Vault Confrontation" pov: "Kaelen" location: "The Lower Spire" value_in: "Powerless (-)" value_out: "Committed (+)" threads: ["th-spire-heist", "th-kaelen-debt"] ---
```

```
# manuscript/chapters/ch-03.md (Flexible Assembly Playlist) --- id: "ch-03" title: "Into the Catacombs" scenes: ["sc-0008", "sc-0009", "sc-0012"] break_rationale: "Climactic cliffhanger: guards breach the outer door as the seal breaks." --- // Moving sc-0012 to Chapter 4 only alters the playlist array!
```

The 5 Workspaces & Scene Graduation.

A disciplined, author-paced state machine from initial brainstorm to publication-grade manuscript via Playbook #19.



01 · Discovery

The Lounge

Story Bible, character DNA, trope stacks, and root author preferences.



02 · Planning

Storyboard Wall

1-Page Foolscap, obligatory genre beats, thread spines, and scene cards.



03 · Drafting

The Writing Desk

Writer's Room sandbox + token-disciplined kits (≤ 6,000 tokens) with voice anchors.



04 · Diagnostics

Editorial Desk

Sub-500ms tell scans, cadence variance, and The Bracket Method.



05 · Publishing

Printing Press

Multi-tier compiler generates publication-grade HTML, EPUB, and Word (.docx).

 The Scene Graduation Ceremony (Playbook #19)

```
node scripts/soundingboard.js graduate <draft>
```

Path 1 (AI Inference): Analyzes draft prose, proposing POV, location, value shifts, and commandments for approval.

Path 2 (Author Scaffold): Injects clean frontmatter template with in-world suggestions from bible and threads commented inline.

Path 3 (Conversational Chat): Discusses turning points and dramatic stakes with author, generating the resulting YAML block.

Your Rhythm, Your Rules:

Author Modes & preferences.md.

A centralized profile at workspace root establishing how the AI interacts with your creative flow.

Solo Mode (Default · 100% Human Words)

Hybrid Mode (Collaborative Volleying)

Generative Mode (On-Demand Drafting)

Solo Mode (The First-Class Default)

You write 100% of the prose in your favorite editor (Obsidian, Scrivener, Word, iA Writer). The AI *never* drafts or modifies prose in your files unless explicitly commanded.

-  **Master Librarian:** Auto-indexes chapter playlists, tracks word counts, and reconciles derived caches.
-  **Continuity Sentry:** Detects proper-noun misspellings, orphaned lore facts, and vanishing daggers.
-  **Diagnostic Partner:** Provides cadence variance and tell density scans on completed scenes.

```
# preferences.md (Workspace Root) working_mode: "solo" # 100% human
prose primary_editor: "obsidian" # or "word", "scrivener"
ai_prose_generation: "never" # zero autonomous text editorial_style:
"bracket_options" tell_tolerance: "moderate" git_mode: "gentle" #
milestone prompts only git_remote_push: "ask"
```

Non-Linear Freedom & 21 Creative Playbooks.

Stages are artifact gates, not rails. Targeted craft playbooks diagnose blocks and accelerate development.

Out-of-Order Drafting

Write your climax today. Soundingboard reverse-engineers missing beat sheets and foolscap backwards from your draft, reconciling differences with you deliberately.

Reverse Engineering Pantsing Friendly

Cross-Book Series Layer

Shared series/ directory tracks romance ladders, heat levels, lore debt ledgers, and village bibles across multi-book sagas without cross-contaminating files.

Multi-Book Memory Lore Debt

21 Codified Playbooks

When blocked, run targeted playbooks rather than vague chat prompts: Unstuck, Dialogue Heat, Sensory Bloom, Causal Calculus, Blind Reader EKG, and Git History.

Targeted Diagnostics Deterministic Packs

 #1 Unstuck (3 Narrative Forks)

 #2 Dialogue Escalation & Heat

 #3 Sensory Bloom

 #5 Causal Plot Calculus

 #15 Blind Reader Simulator

 #18 The Bracket Method

 #19 Scene Graduation

 #20 Linter Bracket

 #21 Git Creative History

The Bracket Method & The Human Red Pen.

Playbooks #18 & #20: Eliminating black-box rewrites forever through quarantined, collaborative choice.

The 4-Phase Diagnostic Protocol

- Phase 1 Objective Diagnosis:** Zero text alterations. Mechanical scans flag cadence monotony, AI tells (>0.50/1k words), or POV voice drift.
- Phase 2 Quarantined Brackets:** Suggestions are isolated in brackets [AI-TELL: ...] alongside verbatim author prose.
- Phase 3 The 3 Author Choices:** Clear options: (1) *Cut* the friction, (2) *Rephrase* with 2–3 voice options, or (3) *Keep* as author voice.
- Phase 4 Author–Executed Revision:** Author makes the decision. The AI never unilaterally applies silent edits.

[PLAYBOOK #18: THE BRACKET METHOD SIMULATOR]

Diagnostic Finding: Explained Theme / Cliché Marker:
"She realized hope was a fragile bird in the winter dusk."

Choose Author Action:

Choice 1: Cut

Choice 2: Rephrase (2 Options)

Choice 3: Keep Voice

> SCRIPT [CUT]: Remove summary sentence entirely. End scene on the cold click of the deadbolt.

Sub-500ms Diagnostics, Thread Lanes & Git History.

Deep story telemetry that tracks subplots, guards continuity, and records creative evolution without gatekeeping.



Sub-500ms Diagnostics

Instant CLI scans for lexical tell density (< 0.50/1k words), sentence rhythm variance, emotional progression, and Shawn Coyne's 5 Commandments.

soundingboard audit commandments



Thread Lanes Visualizer

Tracks character arcs, mystery spines, and relationship subplots. Flags dormant threads and renders interactive SVG trajectory lanes in thread_lanes.html.

soundingboard threads Dormancy Guard



Sovereign Git History

Playbook #21: Git is an open historical log, not a gatekeeper. Commits occur strictly with author consent. Technical integrity is cleanly separated from creative critiques.

soundingboard git Author Checkpoints



Cascading Canon 2.0 & Epistemic Queues: Links world facts to establishing scenes. Three queues track *Orphaned Facts* (cut scenes), *Unbound Entities*, and *Unverified Draft Tags* with strict spoiler thresholds.

✓ soundingboard canon

Pure Creative Flow. A *Real Writing Concierge*.

Soundingboard gives your AI agent the memory, structure, and craft rules to be a true creative partner.



118 Standardized Craft Cards

Swain MRUs, Truby 4-corner opposition, Sanderson magic laws, and Story Grid 5 Commandments embedded in `_config/okf_craft/`. Searchable via CLI.

`soundingboard craft`

`118 OKF Cards`



Universal Rosetta Stone

Speak in whatever storytelling system you love—Story Grid, Save the Cat!, Hero's Journey, or Truby. Soundingboard mirrors your lexicon seamlessly.

`Zero Taxonomy Debates`

`Rosetta Stone`



Health Console & Auto-Healing

`soundingboard status` tracks chapters and SHA-256 staleness, while `soundingboard doctor --fix` heals git, author identities, and paths backstage.

`soundingboard status`

`doctor --fix`

Ready to begin? Start the conversation in chat:

"Read `AGENTS.md` and let's brainstorm my novel."